

Same Event, Different Historian Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	same-event-different-historian

Big idea: Interpretation depends on lens and selection.

Overview

Students compare how historical lenses shape explanation.

Student Prompt

Inspect Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Source packets that foreground economics, leadership, culture, or ordinary people. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Same Event, Different Historian Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A claim comparison chart: evidence used, emphasis, and implied values. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Interpretation depends on lens and selection.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Are some historical interpretations better than others?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how interpretation depends on lens and selection.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: Two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently.
- Source packets that foreground economics, leadership, culture, or ordinary people.
- A claim comparison chart: evidence used, emphasis, and implied values.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Assign each group a different lens.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Groups write a three-sentence explanation of the event.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Groups present and underline what they selected as important.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Students identify which facts were shared and which interpretations differed.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Broken Archive
- Cause Web
- Presentism Trial